

THE DAILY BRIEF

OCTOBER 01, 2026

AI & TECH

Frontier models, agent infrastructure, and the week's biggest tech raises

Google ships Gemini 4 Argon, its first real frontier push in months. Alphabet unveiled Gemini 4 Argon on Wednesday — a 1 million-token output model trained for coding, knowledge work, cybersecurity defense, and creative writing — opening access first to Google AI Ultra subscribers and paid API customers. The launch pricing is \$2 per million input tokens and \$10 per million output tokens, with cached input tokens at 95% off. Google says Argon ties or beats OpenAI's GPT-6 Astra and Grok 4.7 on cybersecurity evaluation benchmarks, and outperforms GPT-6 Astra and Anthropic's Fable 5.1 on the Vals Index — a serious shot across the bow at the current leaders. (TechCrunch, Google Blog)

ElevenLabs doubles to a \$22 billion valuation in an employee tender. The London-based AI voice startup closed a \$300 million secondary offering co-led by Wellington Management and T. Rowe Price, with Goldman Sachs, GIC, Ontario Teachers' Pension Plan, EQT, Sapphire Ventures, and BDT & MSD Partners joining, and existing backers a16z, Alkeon, and D. E. Shaw rolling in. The valuation is up from \$11 billion at its February Series D — the company was valued at \$9 million in 2022. The tender is a liquidity event for employees rather than new capital, but the price tag is the real headline. (TechCrunch, Vestbee)

OpenAI quietly launches a "Decisions API" — a Jev clone aimed at agent control. OpenAI shipped an API with the same shape as TypeSafe AI's Jev model, which TechCrunch reported last week has been thrilling developers since its release on September 18. The interesting twist: OpenAI's framing suggests this is meant to help tame its own swarming agents, not just chase the new category. Cheap, fast model tiers for decision-making look like they're becoming table stakes for frontier labs. (TechCrunch)

An AI startup raised at a \$750M valuation — and the fight over its agent is already ugly. Flow Engineering, an AI agent startup, closed a funding round at a \$750M valuation with Valor, Atreides, and Sequoia participating. Within hours, Flow CEO Mati Staniszewski publicly accused Cognition — the Devin-maker — of using a board adviser to spy on the company. The accusation hasn't been substantiated, but it telegraphs how high the temperature is around agent-foundation startups. (TechCrunch)

Amazon's new Kindle ditches the bezel and adds a remote. Amazon unveiled a smaller, lighter Kindle and a \$35 "Kindle Click" remote for turning pages, plus a new Audible feature that lets readers talk to AI characters from book worlds. Hardware has been quiet at this scale for a while; this is a refresh-and-extend cycle, not a reinvention. (TechCrunch)

MARKETS & FINANCE

Stocks, crypto, and prediction markets

Bitcoin ETF inflow streak snaps after nine days and \$3.1B. U.S. spot Bitcoin ETFs saw \$148.7 million in combined net outflows on Wednesday, ending the longest streak this year. Fidelity's FBTC led the bleed at \$125.6 million, Bitwise's BITB lost \$13.6 million, and BlackRock's IBIT broke its own nine-day, \$1.6 billion run on a \$9.5 million exit. Spot Ethereum ETFs saw \$59.6 million of outflows on the same day, ending a separate seven-day, \$850 million inflow streak. BTC itself whipsawed around \$84,000 after a soft core PCE print (0.2% MoM) cooled October Fed rate hike bets — Bitcoin closed September up 6.4% at roughly \$83,950. (The Block, Farside Investors via KuCoin)

Kalshi is ending its Volume Incentive Program — almost a year early. The prediction market filed with the CFTC on Monday to terminate the program no earlier than October 13, moving up its prior end date of October 1, 2027. The decision lands after the Wall Street Journal reported the CFTC is examining trades on the platform: an X analyst named Beni alleged that repeated ~\$5,500 ether perpetual futures trades inflated Kalshi's ETH perps volume by more than \$5 billion over 30 days, against just \$3.1 million in open interest. Kalshi denies wash trading and says it isn't under investigation; the exchange's monthly volume still hit an all-time high of \$52.98 billion in September as of Sept. 29. (The Block, TradingView, CoinCodex)

Robinhood rolls out perps and weekend stock trading for U.S. users. Robinhood is launching perpetual futures and 24/7 weekend stock trading for its U.S. retail base, alongside a new wallet integration with Arcus RFQ for stock token swaps. Combined, this is the most aggressive push yet by a U.S. retail broker toward around-the-clock, derivatives-heavy markets. (The Block)

Coinbase completes its derivatives stack. Coinbase received CFTC approval for a Designated Contract Market (DCO), letting it list, broker, and clear fully collateralized derivatives in-house — the last piece of an end-to-end derivatives infrastructure play. (The Block)

Bitwise launches the first U.S. spot NEAR ETF with staking. Bitwise's NEAR ETP (ticker NRR) charges a 0.75% fee and stakes its NEAR in-house, passing rewards to shareholders via NAV — a first for a U.S. NEAR product. (The Block)

Crypto advocacy notches a Senate win. Stand With Crypto, the crypto advocacy group, rolled out its first round of Senate endorsements as prediction-market power struggles heat up: the White House is weighing fresh CFTC event contract rules. (The Block)

BRIEFLY

< **Coinbase derivatives** — DCO approval from CFTC, completing full stack. (The Block)

< **Lloyds x Visa** — Settled \$750,000 using USDC in a live cross-border pilot. (The Block)

< **Bitwise ENA call** — Standard Chartered sees 600%+ upside for ENA, expects USDe to hit \$40 billion by 2028. (The Block)

< **FCA opens crypto licensing** — U.K. regulator starts accepting crypto authorization applications ahead of its 2027 regime. (The Block)

< **CFTC Fundsz judgment** — Secured over \$30 million judgment against defendants in Fundsz fraud case. (The Block)

THE TAKEAWAY

The two defining stories of this morning actually rhyme. Google's Gemini 4 Argon is the clearest sign in months that the frontier-model race is back on technical merit — Argon is being pitched on enterprise coding, regulated knowledge work, and autonomous cybersecurity defense, with a price point that puts a 1M-token output model in reach of paid API customers at \$10 per million tokens out. At the same time, ElevenLabs doubling to \$22B in a tender shows that the AI infrastructure layer — voice, audio, agent tooling — is still seeing premium pricing from late-stage capital. Cheap fast models are making Jev-style decision APIs (now a category OpenAI has joined) the new control plane for agent swarms. On the markets side, the Bitcoin ETF streak ending is a reminder that institutional flows into crypto are not a one-way ratchet — the Fed's path still matters — and Kalshi killing its Volume Incentive Program is a credible signal that prediction-market venues will face more scrutiny as their perps books grow. Watch PCE next, and watch how Kalshi structures liquidity going forward.

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